docdesigner: Alpha Testing

Instructions for participants — version 0.11.0

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ABSTRACT

Thank you for taking a look at docdesigner. This alpha asks two questions and only two: **does it work on your machine and your documents, and is it easy to learn?** Comments on how the styles look are welcome too. Please read "What we already know about" (section 5) before you start, so you don't spend time on known issues. Setup and the first task take about fifteen minutes.

1 What this is

`docdesigner` renders R Markdown into publication-quality PDFs. A **style** is a small file of design tokens — typefaces, colours, spacing, rules — that the engine turns into a typeset page. The promise is *same content, any style*: you point one document at a different style and it re-typesets, without your touching a word of the prose.

Sixteen styles ship, in two sets. `academic` holds `minimal`, `modern`, `nature`, `methods`, `demography`, `ssrn`, `sociology`, `ajs`, `thesis` and `qc-thesis`. `public` holds `policy`, `government`, `economist`, `atlantic`, `humanities` and `bulletin`.

This document was itself typeset by docdesigner, in the `methods` style.

2 Setup

You need R, a LaTeX installation providing `xelatex`, and pandoc. RStudio bundles pandoc; TinyTeX and MiKTeX both work for LaTeX. If you have knitted an R Markdown document to PDF before, you already have all three.

2.1 Installing LaTeX in RStudio

If you have never knitted to PDF, install LaTeX from RStudio first. In the RStudio console, run:

```r
install.packages("tinytex")
tinytex::install_tinytex()        # takes a few minutes
tinytex::tlmgr_install("tex-gyre") # a font the bulletin style uses
```

Then restart RStudio. TinyTeX is a small LaTeX installation made for R; it fetches any further LaTeX packages it needs the first time you knit. If you already have MiKTeX, MacTeX or TeX Live, skip this step.

2.2 Installing docdesigner

```r
# install.packages("remotes")
remotes::install_github("jncohen/docdesigner")

library(docdesigner)
designer_check()      # reports anything missing from the toolchain
designer_styles()     # the sixteen styles, with their sets
```

If `designer_check()` reports a problem, fix that before going further. Nearly every confusing failure downstream is a missing `xelatex` or a missing font.

Please tell us how this step went even if it went fine — how long it took, and whether anything was unclear. Installation is the step most likely to lose a new user, and it is the one we can least easily test ourselves.

3 What to try

Three tasks, in order. The second is the important one.

3.1 Render something

Make a new R Markdown document, or take any small one you have, and put this at the top:

```yaml
---
title: "Anything at all"
author: "Your Name"
output:
  docdesigner::pdf:
    style: minimal
---
```

Knit it. That is the whole interface — one line names the style. If this produces a PDF, the package works on your machine.

3.2 Render a real document of your own

This is what we most need. Take a genuine paper, report or memo of yours — the messier the better, ideally one with sections, tables, figures, footnotes and a bibliography — and render it. Then change that one `style:` line and render it again, three or four times:

```
output:
  docdesigner::pdf:
    style: nature      # then sociology, humanities, ssrn, ...
```

We want to know whether **your content survives the switch**. Tables that overflow the page, figures that land in the wrong column, citations that stop resolving, headings that collide with the running head, code that runs off the edge — that is the failure class we cannot find on our own test documents, because our test documents are tidy and yours are real.

Note that `nature` and `economist` are two-column. Wide tables and long code lines are the usual casualty there, and we would like to know how badly.

3.3 Install a style set

```
designer_install_set("academic")
designer_sets()
```

Sets install to your R user directory and survive package updates. This checks that distribution works from a machine that is not ours.

4 Information sought

Beyond outright breakage, the thing we cannot see from here is **where you got stuck**. Specifically:

- What did you have to look up, guess at, or read twice?
- What did you expect to exist and not find?
- Did anything behave differently from how you assumed it would?
- How long did the whole thing take, start to finish?

"I assumed X and it turned out to be Y" is a more useful report than most bug reports. Please send those even when nothing was broken.

5 What we already know about

The styles are designed and every one renders. **Please do comment on how they look.**

Some things are known and do not need reporting:

1. Tables in `nature`, `economist` and `bulletin` move. In a two-column style every table is placed by LaTeX, often after the paragraph that follows it, and a table wider than a column goes to the top of the next page.

2. `minimal` changed in 0.10.0. It is now the plain look of an unstyled R Markdown PDF. The clean preprint style it used to be is now called `modern`.

One thing that is intentional rather than unfinished: **fonts substitute.** Proprietary typefaces are replaced by bundled open ones — XITS for Times, EB Garamond for oldstyle, Source Serif 4 for various. A style being "not quite the real typeface" is expected. A substitution that looks *wrong at the size used* is worth telling us about.

6 How to report

Email **joseph.cohen@qc.cuny.edu**, one message per problem, with `docdesigner feedback` in the subject line.

What makes a report actionable, in rough order of value:

1. **Attach the PDF**, or a screenshot of the part that went wrong. We cannot judge a layout problem from a description.
2. **Which style**, and whether other styles do the same thing. "`sociology` only" and "all sixteen" are different bugs.
3. **A small `.Rmd` that reproduces it.** If your document is confidential, cut it down until it is not — that usually localises the problem anyway.
4. **The output of `designer_check()`**, and of `sessionInfo()`.
5. **What you expected instead.**

If something failed to install, send the full console output, including the error. That is usually enough on its own.